

Leonardo's role did not require him to do any fighting, and when the Borgia campaign ended, he was able to return to Florence in the winter of 1503. However, he was still in search of work.



Sultan Bayezid II

In one of the boldest moves of his career, he proposed some ideas to Sultan Bayezid II, who ruled the empire of the Ottoman Turks from the city of Constantinople (now called Istanbul). It had been 50 years since the Turks had taken the city away from the Byzantine Empire, which traced its roots back to the Romans.

The Turks seemed busy with engineering projects, so Leonardo wrote the Sultan a letter outlining four of his ideas. The first was for a gristmill that would run on wind power rather than flowing water. The second was for a bilge pump, a machine that would remove water without using ropes or pulleys.

What is a sultan?

A sultan is a ruler in some Islamic countries.

